

Philosophy of Science
Prof. James W. McAllister

Lecture 10

Interpretation and Understanding

Motivation of this lecture

- International studies often involves...
 - investigating mental phenomena...
 - with the methods of the human and social sciences
- Interpretive understanding...
 - is the principal technique developed by these disciplines for this purpose
- You will want to be good at it

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Plan of this lecture

- Back to the idiographic approach
 - Introduction to Wilhelm Dilthey
 - Distinction: natural and mental phenomena
- Relationality of mental phenomena
 - How we individuate them in experience
 - Role of *Verstehen*
- Two implications of relationality
 - Purposiveness, meaningfulness
 - How to do research in human sciences

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Reading for this lecture

- Jan Bransen, "*Verstehen and Erklären, Philosophy of*"
 - In Neil J. Smelser and Paul B. Baltes, eds., *International Encyclopedia of the Social and Behavioral Sciences*, pp. 16165–16170
 - Oxford: Elsevier, 2001
- Available on Brightspace

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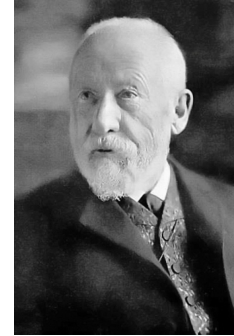
A look ahead

- Wednesday 13 May 2026:
 - Lecture 11, Absolutism and relativism
- Wednesday 20 May 2026:
 - Review, discussion, and question period
 - Final meeting of this course
- Please prepare by...
 - reviewing your notes
 - formulating any outstanding questions

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Wilhelm Dilthey, 1833–1911

- German historian and philosopher
- Taught at the University of Berlin
- Theorised a distinction between an explanatory and a descriptive psychology to account for the first-person perspective



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Dilthey's influence

- Protagonist of German debates...
 - about the status of social sciences and *Geisteswissenschaften* ("human sciences")
 - Late nineteenth, early twentieth century
 - Influenced Max Weber (1864–1920), one of the founders of sociology
- Elaborated the distinction between...
 - nomothetic and idiographic approaches—see lecture 1

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Dilthey's approach 1

- World contains objects of two kinds:
 - Natural phenomena
 - Mental phenomena
- What are similarities and differences between these two categories?

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Dilthey's approach 2

- Like natural phenomena, mental phenomena are...
 - empirical objects in the world, which can be studied by empirical science
 - not objects outside the world, in some abstract realm
 - Dilthey thus rejects idealism
- Unlike natural phenomena, mental phenomena have...
 - content and meaning

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Dilthey's approach 3

- The two sorts of phenomena require...
 - two different scientific methods
- Natural phenomena
 - *Erklären*: to explain outcomes by means of covering laws
 - Method by which a previously individuated natural phenomenon receives explanation
- The DN model of explanation...
 - is in some ways an elaboration of *Erklären*
 - Carl G. Hempel, 1965—see lecture 4

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Dilthey's approach 4

- Mental phenomena
 - *Verstehen*: to understand meanings in an empathetic, interpretive manner
 - Method by which mental phenomena are simultaneously individuated and understood
 - Typical of *Geisteswissenschaften*—and of everyday life
- And social sciences?
 - These too study meaningful human acts by means of *Verstehen*, on Dilthey's view

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Summarising...

- Objects to be investigated by means of *Verstehen*:
 - Social and cultural aspects of human life
- These are characterised by being...
 - Relational
 - Purposive
 - Meaningful
- We now look at these characteristics

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Relationality 1

- The key to the distinction between natural and mental phenomena
 - ... and the ways in which we individuate them in experience
- We can pick out a natural phenomenon from empirical data by ostension
 - Examples: fall of a stone, superconductivity
 - To pick it out, we need not have an explanation of it: *Erklären* may come later
 - How most discoveries in physics are made

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Relationality 2

- We cannot use ostension to pick out mental phenomena, by contrast
 - Central to the identity of a mental phenomenon is its meaning
 - Not possible to individuate a mental phenomenon without having a preliminary understanding of it—provided by *Verstehen*
- Example: gift-giving in anthropology
 - What makes an object a gift? The meanings and significance ascribed to it
 - Not any intrinsic physical properties

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Relationality 3

- Relation science—common sense
 - In natural and human sciences
- In the natural sciences...
 - everyday descriptions of phenomena are routinely replaced by radically different descriptions
 - Example: redescrptions of everyday “solid objects” in atomic and quantum theory
 - We can always fall back on empirical data to identify the phenomenon

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Relationality 4

- In the human sciences, by contrast...
 - it is inconceivable that everyday descriptions of mental phenomena could be replaced by radically different descriptions
 - Why? Because we rely on the everyday description to pick out mental phenomena
- Example: coming-of-age rituals
 - Everyday understanding: markers of a transition from childhood to adulthood

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Relationality 5

- Cultural anthropologists...
 - will extend and enhance this everyday description using more technical concepts
 - but will never replace it by a radically different description, as physicists have done for “solid objects”
- Implications:
 - Human sciences are more rooted in common sense than the natural sciences
 - Kuhnian notion of scientific revolution is less applicable to human sciences

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Purposiveness

- A distinctive feature of human action
 - Not found in modern natural science
 - Follows from relationality
- How can we make sense of human actions?
 - Not by citing any causes of them
 - Rather, by citing their reasons, i.e. rationalising them
 - These reasons are essentially normative

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Purposiveness: example

- I am late for a lecture, so I apologise
 - I apologise not *because* I was late (cause)
 - but *in order to* express regret (reason)
- Furthermore, the reason is normative
 - To make sense of my act of apologising, it is not sufficient to cite facts, such as the time of my arrival
 - It is necessary also to cite the normativity: my degree of lateness was unacceptable

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Meaningfulness

- Things have meaning in virtue of...
 - people’s ascribing meanings to them
- Meaning ascriptions can be multiple and different
 - Though it is not the case that any meaning ascription is as good as any other
- Consequences for the scholar in human sciences:
 - Sensitivity for meaning ascriptions
 - Double hermeneutic

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Sensitivity for ascriptions

- On the one hand...
 - No one person—not even the author of a text—has authority over the meaning to be ascribed
- On the other hand...
 - We cannot capture a phenomenon's meaning irrespective of the meaning ascribed to it by all people for whom the phenomenon plays a role

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Double hermeneutic

- Twin interpretative tasks
 - Any mental phenomenon that we try to interpret has been interpreted before
 - Interpretation addresses both the phenomenon and these pre-interpretations
- A growth in understanding of a phenomenon...
 - goes hand-in-hand with a growth in self-understanding and in understanding of previous interpretations

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Example: *Laocoön and His Sons*

- Roman copy of a Hellenistic sculpture
 - Laocoön, a Trojan priest, and Antiphantes and Thymbraeus, his sons, under attack by sea serpents
 - Unusually complex for an ancient statue
- Made between 30 BCE and 70 CE
 - Rediscovered in a vineyard in Rome in 1506
 - Now on display in the Vatican Museums
- Greatest of all artworks, according to many writers

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***Laocoön*: reception**

- Pliny the Elder (1st cent. CE)
 - "A work superior to any painting and any bronze"
- Influence in Renaissance and Baroque
 - Michelangelo, Titian, Rubens
- Johann Winckelmann (1717–1768)
 - Paradox: seeing beauty in unredeemed pain
- Gotthold Lessing (1729–1781)
 - *Laocoön: An Essay on the Limits of Painting and Poetry* (1766)—source of Romanticism

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***Laocoön*: discussion**

- *Laocoön* today is...
 - partly the physical structure in marble
 - but also the superposition of all comments on and interpretations of it in history
- Any new comment on *Laocoön*...
 - is partly a reflection on previous ascriptions of meaning to the work
 - Any new interpretation must reckon with all earlier interpretations
- Nature of scholarship in human sciences

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Recapitulation 1

- Characteristics of mental phenomena
 - According to Wilhelm Dilthey
- Relationality
 - Individuation of natural phenomena does not require *Erklären*
 - *Verstehen* plays an essential role in the individuation of mental phenomena
 - Unsusceptibility of *Geisteswissenschaften* to scientific revolutions

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Recapitulation 2

- Purposiveness
 - Making sense of human actions by citing reasons
- Meaningfulness
 - Meaning ascriptions
 - Double hermeneutic: understanding a phenomenon goes hand-in-hand with understanding previous interpretations
- Principles of *Verstehen*—characteristic of the human and social sciences

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